

EG US Daily: Troop deaths make de-escalation with Iran more difficult

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US Daily

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Troop deaths make de-escalation with Iran more difficult. The deaths of two US soldiers in an Iranian attack on a base in Jordan—with a third soldier still missing—are the first American fatalities since the breakdown of the June Memorandum of Understanding between the US and Iran.

* The deaths will make it harder for the US to walk away from the conflict, though President Trump's relatively muted reaction indicates they will not force major escalation.

* The US strategy appears unchanged and is focused on degrading Iranian strategic capabilities to force them into a more conciliatory negotiating position. Forcing the re-opening of the Strait of Hormuz through military action alone remains unlikely.

* That the troops were killed in Jordan is indicative of a broader shift in Iranian strategy. Jordan, home to significant American offensive and defensive military assets, has become a more prominent target for Iranian attacks in the past few weeks than it was in the early months of this war.

* Iran has reportedly used advanced missiles to target US bases with unexpected accuracy, and is likely to continue utilizing this capability (see Iran's advanced missile debut has upended Middle East deterrence calculations , 7 April 2026); in addition to the two deaths, they have injured dozens of US servicemembers.

Democrats' Tea Party moment will drag the party left. Progressives are on the upswing in the Democratic Party after defeating moderate incumbents in a series of primary contests, reflecting an emerging generational shift in the party's center of gravity.

* The Democratic Socialist wave is both larger and probably more durable than a similar surge in 2018, and it will likely drive Democrats to the left on a number of policy issues—such as Israel, A.I, and tax policy—over the next two years. Splits such as that which emerged last week among House Democrats over military aid to Israel are likely to be a common occurrence in the coming months and years.

* The presence of a growing and influential activist group, both on the ground and in Congress, will make it harder to execute the centrist turn—especially on social and cultural issues—that many moderate Democrats believe is necessary to reclaim the White House in 2028. Former vice president Kamala Harris’s recent meetings with key far-left figures suggest that many 2028 contenders may come to think a leftward move will prove more beneficial now than it did for much of the Democratic field in 2020.

* The emboldened far-left wing will also make life more difficult for Representative Hakeem Jeffries (D-NY), the presumptive next House speaker if Democrats flip the chamber, and likely pull many 2028 presidential candidates leftward during the primaries.

* For more, please see Democrats’ Tea Party moment will drag the party left , 20 July 2026.

Major restrictions on Hong Kong will remain despite status reversal. Late last week, the US opted to not renew an executive order (EO) dating from 2020 that eliminated Hong Kong’s preferential treatment relative to Mainland China.

* The decision is important for stabilizing US-China bilateral relations but marks a major departure from US policy of the last decade. President Trump signed the original EO in 2020 in response to Hong Kong’s National Security Law and now has decided to let the order lapse as part of larger US-China trade and investment negotiations.

* The EO led to a series of agency-level measures promulgated over the years, treating Hong Kong the same as Mainland China across areas such as immigration, export controls, and extradition agreements. These measures remain in place and are not automatically rescinded. The removal of sanctions on Hong Kong and mainland officials will likely be limited.

* Statutory sanctions are expected to remain in place given bipartisan support in Congress for Hong Kong-related human rights measures. However, further rollbacks on less politically sensitive items like participation in the Fulbright exchange program are available and provide a signpost for the Trump administration’s appetite for further reconciliatory measures.

* For more, see Hong Kong, United States: Core US restrictions will largely remain despite Hong Kong status reversal , 17 July 2026.

Jackson is a worthy Platner replacement—on paper. Former Maine Senate President Troy Jackson became the nearly presumptive Democratic nominee for Senate, replacing Graham Platner, after he won a majority of delegates at county conventions ahead of this weekend’s statewide convention.

* Jackson hits many of the same notes that Platner did. He is an ideological progressive whose personal background as a logger in the far northern forests of the state means that he could, at least on paper, appeal both to the college-educated voters in the Portland area, where high turnout is essential for Democrats, and to blue-collar voters across the small towns of northern and eastern Maine.

* Polling is as yet scant on how Jackson will perform against Senator Susan Collins (R-ME), an electoral juggernaut. An initial round of polling of potential Democratic candidates conducted earlier this month,

before Jackson became the presumptive nominee, suggested he would lead Collins by five points. If post-nomination polling shows a similar lead, that would be a positive sign for Democrats.

* After Platner's exit, prediction markets now see Democrats as roughly 2-1 favorites to win the Maine race, nearly 15 points improved on Platner's chances immediately before his exit; this appears to be an assessment that Jackson can perform in line with Maine's partisan baseline. Initial signs are that this assessment is correct—the Maine race still leans moderately toward Democrats, bolstering their 40% odds of flipping the Senate in November.

Quote of the Day

"Michiganders deserve a senator who will fight for you, not for special interests running millions of dollars in TV ads to buy this seat." – Senator Elizabeth Warren (D-MA) endorsing progressive Abdul El-Sayed in Democrats' Michigan Senate primary, to be held 4 August, which has become a proxy battle between progressives and moderates for the future of the Democratic Party. Warren in her statement is taking implicit aim at the American Israel Public Affairs Committee (AIPAC), which has spent millions on backing the moderate in the race, Rep. Haley Stevens (D-MI), and whose involvement in primaries has become highly contentious among the Democratic base.

On the Radar

21 July: Senate Appropriations Committee hearing on Pentagon's supplemental request

21 July: Senate Select Committee on Intelligence votes on Jay Clayton's nomination for Director of National Intelligence

24 July: Section 122 tariffs expire

27 July: Deadline for Maine Democratic Party to name Senate candidate

27 July – 28 August: House on recess

4 August: Michigan primary election

10 August – 11 September: Senate on recess

3 November: National midterm elections

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Positive: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a positive impact on the macro business environment

Neutral: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a neutral or negligible impact on the macro business environment

Negative: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a negative impact on the macro business environment

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